

Psalms 144

Blessed Be the Lord My Strength

Blessed be the Lord my strength, which teacheth my hands to war
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Blessed be the LORD my strength, which teacheth my hands to war, and my fingers to fight:*
- 2 *My goodness, and my fortress; my high tower, and my deliverer; my shield, and he in whom I trust; who subdueth my people under me.*
- 3 *LORD, what is man, that thou takest knowledge of him! or the son of man, that thou makest account of him!*
- 4 *Man is like to vanity: his days are as a shadow that passeth away.*
- 5 *Bow thy heavens, O LORD, and come down: touch the mountains, and they shall smoke.*
- 6 *Cast forth lightning, and scatter them: shoot out thine arrows, and destroy them.*
- 7 *Send thine hand from above; rid me, and deliver me out of great waters, from the hand of strange children;*
- 8 *Whose mouth speaketh vanity, and their right hand is a right hand of falsehood.*
- 9 *I will sing a new song unto thee, O God: upon a psaltery and an instrument of ten strings will I sing praises unto thee.*
- 10 *It is he that giveth salvation unto kings: who delivereth David his servant from the hurtful sword.*
- 11 *Rid me, and deliver me from the hand of strange children, whose mouth speaketh vanity, and their right hand is a right hand of falsehood:*
- 12 *That our sons may be as plants grown up in their youth; that our daughters may be as corner stones, polished after the similitude of a palace:*
- 13 *That our garners may be full, affording all manner of store: that our sheep may bring forth thousands and ten thousands in our streets:*
- 14 *That our oxen may be strong to labour; that there be no breaking in, nor going out; that there be no complaining in our streets.*
- 15 *Happy is that people, that is in such a case: yea, happy is that people, whose God is the LORD.*

2 · CONTEXT

David blends battle-ready confidence with sober reflection on human frailty, moving from praise of God as his personal strength and fortress, through a request for dramatic deliverance from hostile foreign powers, to a vision of domestic and national flourishing—healthy families, full storehouses, peaceful streets. Henry notes how naturally the psalm moves between military imagery and everyday blessing, refusing to separate a nation's security from its ordinary, daily well-being.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

David blesses the Lord as his strength, the one who teaches his hands to fight, and stacks up descriptive titles—goodness, fortress, high tower, deliverer, shield, refuge—for the God in whom he takes shelter, the one who subdues peoples under him.

Verse 3-4

A sudden turn toward humility: what is man, that God is even mindful of him? Human life is described as mere vanity, days passing like a fleeting shadow—frailty acknowledged in the same breath as confident praise of divine power.

Verse 5-8

David prays for dramatic, direct intervention: bow the heavens and come down, touch the mountains so they smoke, send lightning to scatter enemies, reach from above to deliver from great waters and from the hand of foreign foes whose speech is empty and whose oaths are false.

Verse 9-11

Renewed praise follows the request: David commits to singing a new song, praising with a ten-stringed instrument, recalling how God has delivered David the king from the deadly sword—and prays again for rescue and deliverance from the hand of deceitful foreign enemies.

Verse 12-15

The psalm closes with a vision of flourishing rather than further battle: sons like healthy plants grown strong, daughters like polished corner pillars, storehouses full of every kind of produce, sheep bringing forth thousands, oxen strong for labor, no breach

or going into captivity, no outcry in the streets. The final line names the actual measure of blessing: happy is the people whose God is the Lord.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Confidence in God as a warrior and deliverer is held together with sober honesty about human frailty and, ultimately, with a vision of blessing measured in ordinary domestic peace rather than continual conflict. National well-being, in the psalm's own definition, is not military glory for its own sake but healthy families, full provision, and quiet streets—all traced back to having the Lord as one's God.

Application for life today.

Bring both halves of this psalm into your own prayer: confident trust in God's strength for whatever battle you currently face, alongside honest acknowledgment of your own frailty, as in verses 3–4. Let the psalm's vision of flourishing in verses 12–15 reshape what you actually pray for—not merely victory in conflict, but ordinary, sustained well-being for your household and community. Examine whether you measure your own happiness by the psalm's final standard: having the Lord as your God, rather than by circumstances alone.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What current battle or difficulty calls for the confident trust in God's strength that opens this psalm (vv. 1–2)?

2. How does the psalm's honest acknowledgment of human frailty (vv. 3–4) balance its confident, battle-ready language, and what does that balance look like in your own prayers?

3. By the psalm's own definition of blessing in verses 12–15—healthy family, full provision, quiet peace—how would you currently describe the state of your own household?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).